

closer, following a tragedy in his domestic situation. During the 1940s, his wife began to show signs of dementia. Claire's condition worsened after an operation, as she gradually lost her memory and most of her physical faculties. She entered a sanatorium in 1953 and died there six years later. Yvonne and Messiaen were married in 1961.

Claire's illness cast a shadow over the most successful period of Messiaen's career, when his work gained international recognition. The *Turangalîla* Symphony was a joyous affirmation of the power of love, and he followed this with an ever-deepening fascination with ornithology. Messiaen was by no means the first composer to evoke the sounds of birdsong in his music, but no other has explored the theme so thoroughly. His collections—*Le Réveil des oiseaux*, *Oiseaux exotiques*, and *Catalogue d'oiseaux*—were truly unique, even if they presented an immense challenge for the pianist concerned. Messiaen was able to combine his two great passions—religion and nature—in his last major work, *St. Francis of Assisi*, a five-hour opera on the life of the saint.